of lingering, as if they were waiting to see what was going to happen. I remember Victoria going off to the ladies room and me having this big now-or-never moment with myself. When she came back, I sputtered out an invitation to dinner. I didn't have any sort of plan. I hadn't thought about where we might go. It was just instinctive: I didn't want her to leave. Victoria said she had to go back to London, as the Spice Girls were flying off to America on Monday. But she asked me for my phone number. Without missing a beat, I did the reckoning up. *What? So you can forget you've got it? Or lose it? Or decide not to call?*

'No, Victoria. I'll take your number.'

She scrabbled around in her bag and pulled out her boarding card from the flight up to Manchester that morning. She wrote down her cell phone number, then scratched that out and gave me her number at home at her parents' instead. I still have that precious little slip of card. It was like treasure and I was never likely to lose it. But as soon as I got home, I wrote the number down on about half a dozen other bits of paper and left them in different rooms, just in case.

It usually takes me ages to get off to sleep the night after a game: the adrenaline's still pumping five or six hours later. That particular night, I was buzzing with having met Victoria properly too. I must have slept because I remember waking up late. At about eleven, I picked up The Number and dialed. The voice at the other end sounded just like her but, because I couldn't be sure, I decided to be polite as I could:

'Is Victoria there?'

Just as well I hadn't ploughed straight in. It was her sister, Louise.

'No. She's at the gym. Who is this? I'll get her to give you a call.'

Everybody's been a teenager. A teenager in love. And I'm sure there are plenty of people, like me, who were still getting a bit melodramatic about it all well into their twenties. *She's out at the gym? Well, that's it then: that's the brush off, isn't it? Getting her sister to answer the phone and say she's out.* I didn't actually go and lie down and beat the floor with my fists, but that's what it felt like. I knew Victoria and me had to happen. But maybe she didn't and now it wasn't going to. I just sat on the bed, staring at the phone. Half an hour? An hour? It felt like a week. And then the thing rang.

'David? It's Victoria.'